How to Start a Project with an LLM — Step by Step (v1.3.1)

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Purpose: A repeatable, beginner-friendly procedure for starting a **small or large software project** that you will develop *with* a coding agent such as Codex, OpenCode, or Claude Code.

> **What this guide does:** It gets you from an idea to a real, version-controlled project folder (the **scaffold**) with useful instructions, data contracts where needed, approved skills, and approved MCP servers. **It does not freeze the folder layout forever.** The project and its documentation will evolve as you and your agent build it.

Before you begin

- **You** decide what you want and approve decisions that matter. **The LLM** helps plan and write files. **The coding agent** works in the actual project folder and can help build and test software.
- An **LLM chat** can help draft plans even before you create a project folder. A **coding agent** (Codex, OpenCode, Claude Code, etc.) typically operates on files in that folder.
- **Skill:** a reusable set of instructions or procedures for an agent. **MCP server:** a connection that exposes tools or data to an agent. They are not interchangeable.
- **Scaffold:** the initial working directory, files, configuration and tests—not the finished application.
- You need a terminal, Git, and a coding agent. Some suggested skills use Node.js/npm (`npx`). Install only the tools your selected stack needs. Any illustrative commands are identified by terminal. Your coding agent must generate **all three** setup entry points: Bash, PowerShell, and CMD; verify each where the environment permits.
- **Follow the steps in order.** When a step says *if applicable*, explicitly record **Not applicable** and continue. You should not have to install an unnecessary skill, MCP server, database, UI framework, or validation library for a tiny project.
- **Never paste passwords, tokens, credentials, confidential production data, or personal data into prompts, documentation or Git.** Use synthetic or sanitized examples.

Choose the smallest setup that fits your project

Do not create files just to fill a template. The steps below apply to all projects, but the amount of documentation should match the work. When a step is optional, write **Not applicable** in your planning notes and move on.

Project type	Begin with	Add when needed
Tiny script or experiment	`README.md`, `AGENTS.md`, a runnable program, Git	Brief `PROJECT_SPEC.md`; `ARCHITECTURE.md` if there are important rules
Application with a user interface	Above, plus `DESIGN.md`	Screens, component rules, accessibility checks
Data/import/API/LLM-output project	Above, plus `DATA_CONTRACTS.md`, appropriate `schemas/` or equivalent contracts, validation tests	Migrations and compatibility checks

Project type	Begin with	Add when needed
Complex or collaborative application	Above, plus `ARCHITECTURE.md`, appropriate skills and integrations	Expanded tests, CI, decision records, reviews

How to use this guide: Work down the numbered steps. *You* approve decisions; the *planning chat* drafts specifications; your *coding agent* creates and changes files in the actual repository. A copy/paste prompt can be adapted to your situation. Every step identifies its expected result. You do not need to complete a large paperwork exercise to scaffold a small script.

Which project file does what?

File or folder	Audience	Role	Create or update when
`README.md`	People	What this project does and how to start it	Initial scaffold and user-facing changes
`PROJECT_SPEC.md`	You and agent	Scope, acceptance criteria, project goals	Planning and changed requirements
`AGENTS.md`	Coding agents	Commands, code conventions, safety restrictions, where other rules live	After real scaffold exists, then as workflows change
`DESIGN.md`	Agent / UI contributors	Concrete UI design tokens and interaction rules	UI exists or changes
`ARCHITECTURE.md`	Agent / maintainers	Non-obvious invariants and rationale	Architectural decisions change
`DATA_CONTRACTS.md`	Producers, consumers, agent	Meaning and compatibility of exchanged data	Data interfaces change
`schemas/`	Programs and validators	Machine-readable JSON contracts where appropriate	A structured JSON interface exists or changes
`skills/`	Coding agent	Optional **project-local** reusable procedures, each with a `SKILL.md`	A repeated project-specific procedure is needed
`SKILLS.md`	You and agent	Inventory of selected, installed, and global reusable skills	Skill selection or version changes
`MCP_SERVERS.md`	You and agent	MCP server inventory, permissions and connection setup *without secrets*	MCP selection or configuration changes
`scripts/scaffold.sh`	You and agent	Reproducible initial setup (not a frozen project layout)	Scaffold creation or intentional template evolution

Important distinction: `README.md` explains the project to people; `AGENTS.md` explains how to work *in this repository* to a coding agent; a `SKILL.md` explains a reusable procedure that might work in many repositories. A globally installed skill need not be copied into every project's `skills/` folder. Document its name, source and invocation in `SKILLS.md` instead. Some agents use their own instruction filename or import mechanism; verify the actual supported behavior instead of assuming every agent automatically loads `AGENTS.md`.

START HERE — One prompt to guide your entire first planning session

Do this first: Open a fresh ChatGPT conversation, paste the prompt below, and give a short description of your idea. ChatGPT plans with you; **Codex, OpenCode, Claude Code, or another coding agent creates**

the real files later. You do **not** have to execute 18 prompts independently. This guide also documents the steps so you can inspect or resume them.

> Act as my interactive project-planning facilitator. I am a beginner. Follow this v1.3.1 standard, ask one consequential question at a time, keep a running decision log, challenge assumptions through a mandatory requirements interview, and explain the simplest suitable technical options with trade-offs. Distinguish user requirements, recommendations, assumptions, and unverified claims. Draft and revise specifications, UI design if relevant, architecture, and data contracts if relevant. Evaluate required skills and MCP servers first, then optional recommendations; audit conflicts and security. Do not install tools or generate a real project scaffold during planning. Before handoff, produce a readiness report, obtain my approval, and give me a downloadable structured handoff package for Codex, OpenCode, or Claude Code. Ask for approval on consequential decisions, security risks, tool substitutions, and deviations; otherwise proceed through the steps with me. My project idea: [DESCRIBE IDEA].

Planning completion condition: You approve the final specification and the handoff package. The coding agent then executes the approved plan in a real local repository.

Non-negotiable operating rules (decisions approved in the requirements interview)

Topic	Rule
Responsibility	ChatGPT plans; a coding agent executes scaffolding and subsequent development.
Approval	Routine technical details may be decided by the agent; significant changes, conflicting requirements, security-sensitive actions, and changes to your approved choices require approval.
Interview	Grilling is mandatory, but the number of questions should reflect project complexity. Produce a planning readiness report with unresolved issues.
Baseline capabilities	Evaluate grilling, skill discovery, PRD/issue conversion, and architecture review. Prefer user-specified tools; obtain approval for substitutions. Install only appropriate implementations.
Essential documentation	Create meaningful `README.md` and agent instructions (`AGENTS.md` or verified equivalent). Other files are conditional; explicitly document Not Applicable decisions.
Git	Use commits, a branching policy, version identifiers and relevant tests. Obtain approval before destructive Git operations or publishing.
Security	Assess sensitivity, external transmissions, permissions and credential storage. Never commit secrets or transmit restricted data without permission.
Platforms	Produce **Bash, PowerShell and Windows CMD** setup entry points for **every** project; test where possible and label other platforms NOT VERIFIED. Equivalent setup behavior does not guarantee cross-platform application compatibility.
Verification	Report PASS / FAIL / SKIPPED / NOT VERIFIED with evidence; never claim checks ran when they did not.
Evolution	The project tree can change. Review affected docs, contracts and tests on meaningful changes; approve consequential architecture changes.
Standard governance	Update this guide by approved evidence-based releases; retain old versions, changelog, and synchronized English/Spanish editions.

Three separate completion checkpoints

Do not call a project *ready* until you know **which** milestone you have reached:

Milestone	Who confirms it	Required evidence
Planning complete	You, with ChatGPT	Approved `PROJECT_SPEC.md`, relevant draft design/architecture/contracts, risks, decisions, and a downloadable handoff package
Scaffolding complete	Coding agent, with your review	Created repository, actual initial files, Git baseline, setup scripts and `SCAFFOLD_READINESS.md` showing check outcomes
Development ready	You and coding agent	Agent instructions usable, applicable setup checks verified, unresolved blockers identified, and first development task named

Never substitute one checkpoint for another. A handoff ZIP is not a scaffold; a successful Git commit is not proof that tests passed.

Approval rules (use throughout)

Agent may proceed without another question: choose ordinary implementation details within approved scope, add routine tests, fix reversible setup errors, update relevant documentation, and commit when prior authorization explicitly covers it.

Ask the user first: change core requirements or architecture, replace a user-selected skill/MCP server, expand data access or external transmission, pay for services, delete data, rewrite Git history, publish/deploy, or dispatch parallel workers. Document approvals in `DECISIONS.md` or the handoff decision log.

If approval is unavailable: stop only the affected operation; continue independent safe tasks, and mark the blocked item clearly. Never treat silence as authorization.

PHASE A — Decide what you are building

STEP 1 — Explain your idea in everyday words

Write 2–5 sentences. What should the project do? Who will use it? What is the most important outcome? You do not need technical vocabulary.

You do: Write or dictate your rough idea in an LLM chat.

Result: A short, informal description of your idea.

STEP 2 — Turn the idea into a small, testable project specification

Copy and paste to the LLM:

> Here is my idea: [PASTE IDEA]. Help me create a first-version project specification. State its purpose, intended users, 3–6 core features, what is *out of scope*, how we will know the first version works, a recommended technology stack, and a simple starter folder structure. Separate facts I supplied from your assumptions. Ask me only about decisions that would materially change the plan. Save the approved specification as `PROJECT_SPEC.md`.

Read the draft, correct it, and approve it. Start with the **smallest useful version**; a large project can add features later.

Result: An approved `PROJECT_SPEC.md`.

STEP 3 — Clarify uncertain requirements (a grilling interview)

A *grilling* skill asks focused questions to expose hidden assumptions. You can conduct the interview in the planning chat **without installing a skill yet**. Later, if you install `grill-with-docs`, it can revisit and document decisions inside the repository.

Copy and paste:

> Interview me about the proposed project. Focus on missing requirements, conflicting assumptions, expected users, inputs and outputs, edge cases, success criteria, and restrictions. Ask one important question at a time. Keep a short decision log and update `PROJECT_SPEC.md` after I approve the answers. Stop when the project is clear enough to scaffold.

Result: Clearer requirements and a short list of decisions or unresolved questions. **Do not wait for every future implementation detail to be known.**

STEP 4 — Draft the three project-rule documents

These describe different concerns. **Create short, useful files rather than long speculative documents.**

Document	Question it answers	When needed
`DESIGN.md`	How should screens look and behave?	**If the project has a UI** (web, desktop, mobile, CLI with a significant interactive interface)
`ARCHITECTURE.md`	How should the system be organized, and which rules must never be broken?	**All projects**; very brief for tiny scripts
`DATA_CONTRACTS.md`	What data enters, leaves, or passes between components, and what does it mean?	**Any project with structured data exchange, files, APIs, configuration or structured LLM output**

Copy and paste:

> Using `PROJECT_SPEC.md`, draft `ARCHITECTURE.md` (system parts, important invariants and technology decisions). If there is a user interface, also draft `DESIGN.md` (design tokens, layout, components, behavior for loading/errors, responsiveness and accessibility). Identify whether the project has structured data inputs/outputs; if so, draft `DATA_CONTRACTS.md` (data producers, consumers, formats, semantics and validation rules). Keep these documents appropriate to the project's size. If something does not apply, say why. Flag contradictions among the documents before I approve them.

For a simple command-line script, `DESIGN.md` may be **Not applicable** in the planning checklist and need not exist. A tiny script may record its few technical rules directly in `AGENTS.md` and skip a separate `ARCHITECTURE.md`; for nontrivial systems, keep it explicit.

If you create `DESIGN.md`: Ask for actual values, not vague adjectives. For example, include YAML front matter or a table containing hex color tokens, font stacks, spacing scale and corner radii. Add layout, components, keyboard accessibility, loading/error states and responsive rules. This prevents one agent session from changing the design unintentionally in the next. Keep it short for a small UI.

Result: Approved rule documents appropriate to your project.

STEP 5 — Define machine-checkable data contracts (when needed)

If your project receives or produces structured data, decide **exactly what shape it has before writing the modules that consume it**. Examples: CSV imports, API requests and responses, JSON config, messages between modules, and structured LLM responses.

A **JSON Schema** describes constraints on JSON data. It can specify names, types, required fields, allowed values, numeric bounds and conditional structure. **It does not by itself prove every business rule** (such as an actuarial formula, uniqueness across database records, or equality between two separately stored

totals). Use code/tests for those extra rules. For CSV, binary, database tables or other formats, document their native contract too; a JSON Schema is not automatically the right format for everything.

Copy and paste:

> From `PROJECT_SPEC.md`, `ARCHITECTURE.md` and `DATA_CONTRACTS.md`, inventory each data producer, consumer, input, output, and transformation. For JSON interfaces, create schemas in `schemas/` using an explicitly stated JSON Schema draft (prefer Draft 2020-12 unless my tools require another). Specify required fields, types, enums, nullability, units, dates, IDs, ranges, optional fields and error behavior. For non-JSON formats, document an equivalent contract. Generate **synthetic** valid, invalid and boundary examples and identify rules requiring additional code-based tests. Do not invent field names or domain semantics; list unresolved questions. Explain how contracts will be validated and versioned.

Suggested small structure (only what is needed):

```
schemas/
  inputs/
  outputs/
  config/
  examples/valid/
  examples/invalid/
tests/contracts/
```

Only create subfolders that your project actually uses. For example, an API project could use `schemas/api/create-order.schema.json`, and an agent-configuration project could use `schemas/config/opencode.schema.json`. Do not force JSON Schema onto CSV or relational data; use an appropriate format-specific contract. Establish a compatibility policy: changes that break an existing producer or consumer require explicit review, migration or coordinated release. Decide whether contract versions are carried by filenames, schema IDs, API versions or another clear mechanism.

Result: Approved `DATA_CONTRACTS.md`, relevant schema files (for example `schemas/inputs/import.schema.json`), synthetic examples and a validation plan. If there is no structured data exchange, record **Not applicable**.

PHASE B — Choose agent skills and MCP connections

Important distinction: In this phase you are **selecting and reviewing** tools. Project-local installation will happen **after the folder and Git repository exist**. This avoids a common ordering problem.

STEP 6 — Review a baseline set of reusable skills

These are **candidates to consider for nearly every project**, not an instruction to install all of them automatically. Verify their current names and sources before installing; upstream repositories may change.

Skill	Appropriate usage
`grill-me` **or** `grill-with-docs`	Challenge requirements. Use **one main interviewing approach**; `grill-with-docs` is especially suitable once project files exist and decisions should be documented.
`find-skills`	Discover skills for a newly identified project need. Discovery **does not** authorize automatic installation.
`to-prd` → `to-issues`	Turn approved requirements into a Product Requirements Document (PRD), then actionable issues. Run `to-issues` **only after** approving the PRD and preparing an issue tracker.
`improve-codebase-architecture`	Review/refactor an **existing** body of code. **Do not** run as a mandatory refactor on an empty scaffold.
`setup-matt-pocock-skills`	Configure the supporting workflow in a suitable, initialized repository, if you use that toolset.

To inspect what's actually offered (do not install blindly):

```
npx skills@latest add mattpocock/skills --list
npx skills@latest add vercel-labs/skills --list
```

Example targeted install commands (run **after Step 12**, inside the new project, if approved and supported by your coding agent):

```
npx skills@latest add mattpocock/skills --skill grill-with-docs
npx skills@latest add vercel-labs/skills --skill find-skills
npx skills@latest add mattpocock/skills --skill to-prd --skill to-issues
npx skills@latest add mattpocock/skills --skill improve-codebase-architecture
npx skills@latest add mattpocock/skills --skill setup-matt-pocock-skills
```

Optional alternative to `grill-with-docs`:

```
npx skills@latest add mattpocock/skills --skill grill-me
```

The name `prd-to-issues` may describe the desired workflow; the **two skills shown above** are `to-prd` and `to-issues`. An agent may expose skills as slash commands (such as `/to-prd`), as a named skill, or through another interface. **Ask your agent how to invoke the installed skill; do not assume all agents support identical slash commands.**

References: https://skills.sh/mattpocock/skills · https://skills.sh/vercel-labs/skills/find-skills

STEP 7 — Add YOUR required skills, then seek optional suggestions

Copy and paste:

> The skills I require are: [LIST NAMES, REPOSITORIES OR LINKS]. Keep my choices separate from optional recommendations. Check compatibility with my chosen coding agent. Recommend only additional skills that serve a distinct purpose. Explain when each should be used; do not install anything yet.

Where skills live: A skill can be installed globally in your agent environment (portable across repositories) or locally for a specific project. Do not copy a global skill into each project unless your agent requires it or you deliberately need a pinned, project-specific version. Each local skill normally has its own `SKILL.md`, for example `skills/release-checklist/SKILL.md`. Keep a source/version/install-scope inventory in `SKILLS.md`.

Result: One proposed skill manifest: **required by user**, **recommended**, **accepted/rejected**, **reason**, **installation source**, **when to invoke**. This will become `SKILLS.md`.

STEP 8 — Audit skill conflicts before installing

Copy and paste:

> Examine documentation and configuration for every selected skill. Identify duplicates, contradictory instructions, overlapping responsibilities, dependency/version mismatches, permissions, and competing configuration files. Write `SKILL_CONFLICT_REPORT.md` with columns: Skill A, Skill B, evidence, severity (Critical/Moderate/Minor), recommended resolution, and status. Preserve user-required skills when technically and safely possible; ask me about substitutions. Separate **verified** conflicts from **potential** conflicts. If none are found, state 'No skill conflicts detected' and specify what was checked. Do not install skills with unresolved critical conflicts.

Result: An accepted `SKILL_CONFLICT_REPORT.md`. Compatible overlaps need not be removed; assign distinct responsibilities when useful.

STEP 9 — List YOUR MCP servers, then consider optional suggestions

An MCP server gives the coding agent access to capabilities such as repository operations, databases, external services, or documentation. **MCP is optional:** a simple offline script may not need any server.

Copy and paste:

> My required MCP servers are: [LIST, OR 'none']. State what each server connects to, which operations I expect, and whether the chosen coding agent supports it. Suggest only complementary servers, including their official sources and required permissions. Do not install or authorize them yet.

Result: An approved `MCP_SERVERS.md` plan, or **No MCP servers needed**.

STEP 10 — Audit MCP conflicts and permissions

Copy and paste:

> Audit every selected MCP server for duplicate tool names, competing writes, incompatible runtimes, transports, versions, ports, authentication, file/network access and excessive permissions. Write `MCP_CONFLICT_REPORT.md` with evidence, severity, resolution and verification status. Do not enable unresolved critical conflicts. Do not request secrets in chat or place credentials in repository files.

Result: An approved `MCP_CONFLICT_REPORT.md`, or a short **Not applicable** entry if there are no MCP servers. Remember that merely reviewing configuration does not prove the connection works.

Handoff-package validation (required before sending to the coding agent)

ChatGPT should deliver **one downloadable ZIP** with meaningful, internally consistent planning files—not a ZIP of empty directories. The specific files depend on project needs. A reasonable package contains:

```
project-handoff/
  START-HERE.md             # exact steps to give the package to the coding agent
  PROJECT_SPEC.md           # approved goals, scope, acceptance criteria
  DECISIONS.md              # user approvals, assumptions and unresolved items
  AGENT_HANDOFF.md          # agent instructions and authorized actions
  ARCHITECTURE.md           # if needed
  DESIGN.md                 # if a UI is needed
  DATA_CONTRACTS.md         # if structured data is exchanged
  schemas/                  # if machine-readable contracts are needed
  SKILLS.md                 # requested/approved skills, sources and invocation
  MCP_SERVERS.md            # approved servers, permissions (no credentials)
  READINESS_PLAN.md         # checks to execute after scaffolding
```

Before delivery, check: **(1)** the spec and architecture do not contradict one another; **(2)** mandatory user requirements are present; **(3)** every required interface has an owner and relevant contract; **(4)** unresolved critical conflicts are blockers; **(5)** SKILLS/MCP entries distinguish requested, recommended, approved, installed and unverified; **(6)** there are no embedded secrets; **(7)** the agent's allowed actions and approval gates are explicit; **(8)** the recipient can find the first action in `START-HERE.md`.

The package is a **planning output**, not evidence that the scaffold or installations already exist. If ChatGPT cannot create the ZIP, provide the complete documents individually and report the packaging limitation.

PHASE C — Approve and hand off planning; let the coding agent scaffold

STEP 11 — Confirm the planning readiness gate

Ask ChatGPT:

> Audit my approved specification, `DESIGN.md` if applicable, `ARCHITECTURE.md`, `DATA_CONTRACTS.md` and schema definitions if applicable, selected skills/MCP servers, platform restrictions, security choices and test strategy. Identify contradictions, missing decisions, and unverified technical assumptions. Classify each finding as BLOCKING or NON-BLOCKING and report PASS, FAIL, SKIPPED, or NOT VERIFIED with the basis for the result. Continue grilling until blocking matters are resolved. Request my explicit approval to hand off.

Result: Approved `PLANNING_READINESS.md` and decision log. **Never call an untested assumption verified.**

STEP 12 — Export the structured handoff package

Ask ChatGPT:

> Produce one downloadable archive named `PROJECT-HANDOFF-v0.1.0.zip` with the final approved plan, a `HANDOFF.md` telling a coding agent exactly what to do, `PROJECT_SPEC.md`, `DECISIONS.md`, `PLANNING_READINESS.md`, conditional `DESIGN.md`, `ARCHITECTURE.md`, conditional `DATA_CONTRACTS.md` and `schemas/`, `SKILLS.md`, `MCP_SERVERS.md`, plus acceptance criteria and a brief `SECURITY.md`. The contents are specifications and proposed configuration, not a claim that the repository or external tools have been created. Supply versioned files; do not put secrets in the archive. Include a manifest of included files and intentional omissions.

Result: Downloadable handoff ZIP. If a file cannot be generated, clearly identify the gap rather than invent a download link.

STEP 13 — Open the coding agent and supply the package

Open Codex, OpenCode, Claude Code or the chosen alternative in a new or designated project directory. Give it the ZIP (or extracted directory) and this instruction:

> Read `HANDOFF.md` and all referenced specifications. Check the actual machine, available software, permissions, internet restrictions and current tools. Present your proposed execution plan. Preserve user-approved decisions; ask before substitutions, architectural deviations, restricted network access or publishing. Create the complete initial scaffold and actual starter files, not an empty directory template. Report anything that cannot be completed.

Result: An agent-executed plan, with the beginner approving consequential changes.

STEP 14 — Have the agent create and version the scaffold

The agent creates functional starter files and `README.md`, drafts/updates appropriate `AGENTS.md` (or agent-specific equivalent), links to the design/architecture/contracts, and generates an idempotent scaffold procedure. **Every project must provide all three setup entry points:**

```
scripts/setup.sh          # Bash (Linux/macOS/WSL/Git Bash as applicable)
scripts/setup.ps1         # Windows PowerShell
scripts/setup.cmd         # Windows Command Prompt
```

The scripts should offer equivalent documented setup tasks; they may invoke common internal logic. Do not assume identical package managers or admin privileges. Keep secrets in ignored local configuration, check `.gitignore`, run `git init` where needed, and create the first clean commit. **Do not force-push, overwrite existing work, or publish without approval.**

Result: Real repository, three setup entry points, meaningful files and a traceable initial commit.

STEP 15 — Install approved capabilities and initialize agent context

The coding agent installs **only approved** skills and MCP servers in their verified scope (global or project-local), checks names/versions and capabilities, and tests permitted connections. Record successes, failures and approval-gated substitutions in `SKILLS.md` and `MCP_SERVERS.md`. Initialize agent instructions using `/init` **only where supported**, otherwise use the tool's documented equivalent. Confirm that agent instructions reference the applicable `DESIGN.md`, `ARCHITECTURE.md`, `DATA_CONTRACTS.md` and skills. Credentials must not appear in Git.

Result: Agent context and approved tools configured or explicitly classified as unavailable/unverified.

STEP 16 — Verify the scaffold and show the beginner how to proceed

Ask the coding agent:

> Run all checks actually supported in this environment: executable starter, dependencies, configuration, relevant schema examples, tests, selected skill invocation, approved MCP connections, and the supported platform setup scripts. Report each as PASS, FAIL, SKIPPED, or NOT VERIFIED and include the command or observable evidence. Do not infer that untested Windows or Linux scripts work. Supply a `SCAFFOLD_READINESS.md`, Git commit identifier and simple copy/paste instructions to run, test and resume development. Commit validated changes without publishing unless authorized.

A FAILURE must be corrected or clearly disclosed. **NOT VERIFIED is not PASS.**

Result: A verified baseline, evidence-backed readiness report, incomplete-task list, and a precise next action for the beginner.

PHASE D — Build and keep the project healthy

STEP 17 — Plan the first small development task

The initial scaffold is **not** a complete application. Ask the agent to turn the approved specification into small changes with tests. If you selected Matt Pocock's workflow, use `to-prd` to refine the PRD and `to-issues` **after** PRD approval and issue-tracker setup. Otherwise, a simple task checklist is sufficient. A beginner need not use an issue tracker for a tiny script.

Copy and paste:

> Read the repository's project rules. Propose the smallest useful feature to build next, with acceptance criteria and a way to test it. Identify which files and data contracts it affects. Implement one reviewable change at a time, run appropriate tests, summarize what changed, and commit only after I approve the result or give you explicit authority to commit.

Result: An incremental development cycle, not one giant untestable generation.

STEP 17A — Optionally parallelize approved development issues using sub-agents

After the PRD is **approved**, use `to-prd` then `to-issues` (or approved equivalents) to create an actionable issue list with acceptance criteria, dependencies, ownership and affected interfaces. **Do not automatically assign every issue to a separate agent.**

Ask the coding agent:

> Inspect the approved `to-issues` output. Build a dependency graph and identify independent issues with nonoverlapping write sets and stable interfaces. Propose a parallel execution plan, with one orchestrator, worktree or branch per worker, issue ownership, integration order, test requirements and a fallback to serial execution. Explain races, shared-file conflicts and integration cost. Ask for my approval before dispatching sub-agents or enabling paid external services. Never run dependent work simultaneously without an agreed interface contract.

Rules: The orchestrator owns the issue graph and final integration. Sub-agents do not edit the same shared files concurrently without coordination. Independent tasks can run in parallel; dependent tasks run in order. Each worker produces a focused change, tests and a summary; orchestrator reviews merges, re-runs integration/contract tests and documents the results. If the agent cannot launch sub-agents, proceed serially with the same issue plan. This option is **Not Applicable** for projects where parallel work would add more overhead than value.

Result: Approved parallel plan and integrated verified issues, or a documented sequential alternative.

STEP 18 — Let the project tree evolve, but maintain the contracts and instructions

As you build, the agent may add folders, rename modules, change dependencies or propose new architecture. **This is expected.** `scripts/scaffold.sh` records the **initial setup**; it is not an order to reset the project to its original shape. Keep `README.md`, `ARCHITECTURE.md`, `DESIGN.md`, and `DATA_CONTRACTS.md` aligned with the software that actually exists.

Before accepting a change, ask:

> Does this change affect the architecture, UI rules, data producers/consumers, schemas, skills, MCP servers, permissions or build commands? If so, update the relevant documents and tests in the same change. Check schema compatibility and migrations before changing data interfaces. Re-run conflict audits if skills or MCP servers changed. Show me the verification results and any unresolved risks.

Re-run agent initialization or update `AGENTS.md` when the structure changes materially; **review its output because automated initialization can overwrite custom guidance**. Use `improve-codebase-architecture` only after meaningful code exists and you want an architectural review. Commit useful checkpoints and preserve history.

Result: A growing project that remains understandable to both you and future agent sessions.

Agent compatibility: verify rather than assume

Capability	Codex	OpenCode	Claude Code	Required action
Repository instructions	Commonly uses `AGENTS.md`	Agent/project instruction support varies by configuration	Commonly uses `CLAUDE.md`	Check installed version and load/import appropriate project instructions
Initialization command	Depends on interface/version	`/init` where supported	`/init` where supported	Inspect the tool's help; do not assume identical commands
Skills / slash invocations	Supports agent skills in supported environments	Skills and commands depend on version/plugins	Supports skills in supported environments	Confirm installation path, discovery and actual invocation
MCP servers	Available in supported configurations	Available in supported configurations	Available in supported configurations	Check transport, permissions and a harmless test call

Capability	Codex	OpenCode	Claude Code	Required action
Parallel sub-agents	Configuration-dependent	Configuration-dependent	Configuration-dependent	Verify support and budget; otherwise serialize tasks

These are orientation notes, not an installation compatibility guarantee. The coding agent must verify its installed version and document actual results before claiming PASS. Global and project-local skill installations are different scopes.

When something fails: beginner recovery procedure

1. **Stop repeating the failing command.** Copy the exact error and the command into the agent chat, excluding any secrets.
2. Ask: *"Explain the failure in plain language. Is it a missing prerequisite, wrong terminal, restricted permission, version mismatch, credential problem, network issue, dependency conflict, or genuine code defect?"*
3. Ask the agent for the **smallest reversible fix**, what it would change, and the way to confirm success; require approval first if it affects security, user choices, or published history.
4. Re-run the failed check and record its actual result in `SCAFFOLD_READINESS.md` as **PASS / FAIL / SKIPPED / NOT VERIFIED**, including command, platform and observed output.
5. If the environment cannot support the check, mark **NOT VERIFIED**, document a manual or alternative test, and continue only where no safety or dependency blocker exists.
6. If setup is damaged, return to the last known-good Git commit **without discarding uncommitted work**; inspect `git status` and obtain approval before destructive operations.

Special cases: If a skill is not discovered, confirm its exact installation scope/name and reload the agent; if an MCP connection fails, check permissions and credentials without exposing secrets; if the Git push fails, preserve local commits and diagnose remote/authorization issues; if PDF/ZIP download fails, use the committed Markdown or repository's download option rather than assuming the file is missing.

Small end-to-end dry run (acceptance test for this standard)

Before treating this guide as validated on a specific agent, follow it once on a **non-sensitive toy project** (for example, a CLI that validates a small synthetic JSON file). Record evidence that the planning interview, handoff, scaffold scripts, Git baseline, agent initialization, starter execution, contract test if applicable and final readiness report actually worked.

Testing checklist:

- [ ] ChatGPT generated an approved handoff package; recipient agent located `START-HERE.md`.
- [ ] The agent built actual files and committed the initial baseline.
- [ ] Bash, PowerShell and CMD setup entry points exist and are semantically equivalent; untested environments are marked NOT VERIFIED.
- [ ] Applicable starter run, skill discovery, MCP checks and test commands have recorded results.
- [ ] The beginner can identify the next action and recover from an induced, reversible failure.
- [ ] English and Spanish documents have equivalent steps and release numbers.

Evidence rule: This checklist is a procedure to run, **not a claim that the dry run has been completed**. Record the date, environment, commands and outcomes when somebody actually performs it.

Appendix — example prompts for maintaining the agent context

When creating or updating `AGENTS.md`, a useful concise instruction is:

> Read `PROJECT_SPEC.md` for scope, `ARCHITECTURE.md` for system invariants, `DESIGN.md` for UI conventions (if present), `DATA_CONTRACTS.md` and `schemas/` for data interfaces (if present), and `SKILLS.md` / `MCP_SERVERS.md` for approved agent capabilities. Read `scripts/scaffold.sh` only when investigating or changing setup. Use the actual build and test commands in this repository; never invent missing files or commit secrets.

A basic project-local skill can be stored as `skills/<skill-name>/SKILL.md` with a clear name, description, when to invoke it, ordered procedure and verification checks. Whether the agent auto-discovers that directory is **tool-specific**; confirm the required path with the agent's documentation. Install sources only after reviewing their content and permissions.

When you change the project tree, **update references**, but do not routinely overwrite manually maintained documents by re-running an agent's initialization command. Review diffs and commit the changes.

Quick completion checklist

- [ ] My first-version goals and boundaries are written in `PROJECT_SPEC.md`.
- [ ] `ARCHITECTURE.md` states real system rules; `DESIGN.md` exists if a UI is needed.
- [ ] Data producers/consumers are identified; schemas and synthetic tests exist where appropriate.
- [ ] My required skills and MCP servers are distinguished from optional recommendations.
- [ ] Skill/MCP conflicts were reviewed; critical conflicts are resolved before installation.
- [ ] The scaffold creates real files and a runnable starter project.
- [ ] Git has at least one baseline commit; no secrets are committed.
- [ ] My chosen coding agent can read the project rules and invoke approved tools.
- [ ] The baseline tests pass, or failures and blockers are explicitly documented.
- [ ] I understand that the initial tree is a starting point, not a permanent structure.

The entire process in one line

Idea → specification → clarify → design/architecture/data contracts → choose and audit skills/MCP → scaffold → Git baseline → configure tools → initialize agent → verify → build small features → update documents, schemas, tests and Git as the project evolves.

Version control of THIS reusable standard

The guide itself is a **separate living standard**, not the version number of any project you start with it.

- Use `MAJOR.MINOR.PATCH`: **MAJOR** for incompatible major workflow changes; **MINOR** for new compatible phases or guidance; **PATCH** for editorial corrections.

- Every release changes the version in the **title**, **filename** and **metadata**, and adds an entry to the revision history below. Preserve prior versions in Git or a versioned archive. Do not overwrite the old release under its old versioned name.
- Suggested Git commit: `docs(standard): release v1.3.1`; optional tag: `project-standard-v1.3.1`.
- The standard can be used with different operating systems, agents and programming languages. Agent-specific commands may change; check official instructions before executing them.

Revision history

Version	Date	Changes
1.3.1	2026-10-18	Stabilization: completion checkpoints, approval gates, validated handoff package, agent compatibility notes, troubleshooting, dry-run protocol, cross-platform wording and corrected revision history.
1.3.0	2026-10-18	Approved 18-question grilling decisions, interactive master prompt, structured agent handoff, cross-platform setup, evidence-based readiness and optional dependency-aware sub-agents.
1.2.0	2026-10-18	Merged Project Bootstrap Kit concepts into one beginner guide: file responsibility matrix, global vs local skills, concrete design tokens, minimum viable configurations, agent-file portability, scaffold regeneration safeguards and explicit human/agent documentation separation.
1.1.0	2026-10-18	Reorganized into a literal beginner workflow; added `PROJECT_SPEC.md`, explicit conditional `DESIGN.md`, `DATA_CONTRACTS.md`, JSON Schema design/verification, clearer tool install timing, real scaffold checks, agent initialization and evolving-project maintenance.
1.0.0	2026-10-18	First versioned baseline: reusable skills, MCP selection and installation, conflict audits, scaffolding, agent context and Git guidance.